

Chapter 64-1

Qi Jiao used to love tying her hair up, using large hair ties to bundle it together.

But today her hair was loose and flowing, with the hair tie around her wrist.

Just as she flipped her hair in that instant, Liang Shi saw her wounds.

In less than a second, all those scars were covered by her hair.

Almost instinctively, Liang Shi jogged a few steps to stand in front of her, blocking her path.

"What happened to your injuries?"

Qi Jiao stepped back, creating distance between them, her eyes evasive. "There are no injuries, you saw wrong."

"Was it your mother who did this?" Liang Shi asked again.

Qi Jiao pressed her lips together, her gentle voice carrying a hint of impatience. "I already said you saw wrong."

She moved to the side, gripping her canvas bag tightly. "You've picked up the child, so please leave quickly. I hope you'll spend your time on the children."

Her tone was already cold, her brows furrowed into a small mountain, but her eyes didn't show impatience—rather, deep fear.

Liang Shi continued to block her path, the first time in her life doing such a thing. She wasn't very skilled at it and nearly tripped over her own feet, but Qi Jiao reached out to steady her.

Liang Shi felt embarrassed. "Thank you."

Qi Jiao withdrew her hand. "Really, there's no need to do this anymore."

But Liang Shi didn't give up. She felt she was being somewhat unreasonably persistent.

However, regarding this matter, she wanted to get to the bottom of it.

She even... wanted revenge.

Every domestic abuser should be punished.

Moreover, to the childhood version of herself, Mrs. Qi's actions constituted intentional harm and child abuse.

Although more than twenty years had passed, even if evidence from that time could be found, it wouldn't be possible to file a case or seek justice.

But... shouldn't bad people receive punishment?

Otherwise, there would be new victims.

For example—Qi Jiao, standing before her now.

"So you're just going to endure this kind of harm forever?" Liang Shi asked solemnly.

Qi Jiao closed her eyes and let out a soft breath. "Miss Liang, this has nothing to do with you."

"But I was also a victim," Liang Shi immediately retorted. "Should I just pretend nothing happened?"

Qi Jiao: "..."

After a long silence, Qi Jiao said coldly, "Go find whoever did it to you. Don't keep pestering me."

Liang Shi's breath caught. Qi Jiao had already slipped past her and was walking away quickly.

Liang Shi stared at her retreating figure and said with some helplessness, "Have you really never thought about fighting back?"

Qi Jiao's steps faltered slightly, but she still left without looking back.

She said nothing.

As the sun set in the west and the crowds dispersed, the kindergarten entrance seemed somewhat desolate.

Qi Jiao's silhouette was forlorn. She was thin and seemed to merge with the rustling autumn wind, yet her steps were firm and determined.

Liang Shi stood in place for a long time, feeling nothing but heartache.

Chapter 64-2

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When Liang Shi returned to the car, Ling Dang was sitting in the back left seat watching her iPad, while Rainbow held a novel in her hands.

She glanced at the cover—it was a very famous science fiction novel in this world.

Online reviews of this book were mixed: those who understood it praised it to the skies, while those who didn't were completely bewildered.

Some people even used education level to categorize readers, claiming that 90% of those who could understand this book had at least a bachelor's degree.

Although this hadn't been verified through big data, most people agreed with this assessment.

It seemed Rainbow was a science fiction fan.

Even though she had been with Rainbow for quite some time, Liang Shi still couldn't quite adapt to this genius girl's persona.

At five years old, she was reading science fiction novels that many adults found obscure, and she was completely absorbed in them, while her peers were still reading "Bunny Don't Cry."¹

However, Liang Shi had come to accept this reality.

There were simply people in this world whose starting point was farther than others' endpoints.

Besides, children who read science fiction novels weren't necessarily unhappy.

Liang Shi turned around to ask the two children, "Do you want to eat something or play?"

Rainbow was the first to put down her book. "Sister Liang, can we have both?"

"You're so greedy," Ling Dang paused her cartoon and said disdainfully.

"Don't you want both too?" Rainbow asked back.

Ling Dang was silent for two seconds, then looked at Liang Shi with a sweet smile. "Auntie, I want to eat first and then play."

Rainbow: "..."

She sighed helplessly.

Liang Shi looked at Ling Dang, who was leaning her head over, touched her head, and readily agreed: "Alright."

Then she asked for Rainbow's opinion. Rainbow said indifferently, "Either is fine."

Ling Dang scoffed.

The two children seemed to not get along well.

Last time Liang Shi heard Ling Dang mention something about how the little friend Ling Dang liked also liked Rainbow, so Ling Dang was hostile toward Rainbow.

However, Rainbow was still immersed in her own science fiction world, acting like a little adult, completely unable to understand Ling Dang's inexplicable hostility.

But when it came time to eat, Liang Shi still quietly educated Ling Dang: "Rainbow is Auntie's friend's child, you can't bully her, okay?"

"I didn't," Ling Dang said proudly. "I didn't even use my hands."

Liang Shi: "..."

She made a fist and waved it in front of Ling Dang. "If you dare use your hands, I'll beat you up, okay?"

Ling Dang pouted. "Auntie, you're being partial."

Liang Shi: "I'm teaching you not to target other children."

"But Shen Yiran won't play with me anymore because of her," Ling Dang said, tears welling up in her eyes. "She even said she wants to transfer to Zhou Caihong's class, wuu wuu wuu."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"Even if she says she wants to transfer, her mom might not actually transfer her," Liang Shi comforted. "And you don't only have Shen Yiran as a good friend. You can be good friends with Rainbow too."

"I don't want to!" Ling Dang said huffily. "She actually said 'Bunny Don't Cry' is a childish cartoon."

Liang Shi: "..."

Never having dealt with such childish conflicts before, Liang Shi felt quite a headache. She pressed her temples and immediately changed the subject, glossing over this matter.

She chose to let things take their natural course.

She took the two children to eat fast food again.

Originally, she had planned to have Cantonese cuisine, but Ling Dang said she didn't like drinking soup, and Rainbow suggested wanting hamburgers.

Faced with two children's pitiful pleading eyes, Liang Shi had no judgment whatsoever.

She drove to McDonald's in a daze.

There weren't many people in the restaurant now, and it was quite quiet.

The entire floor had only two tables of people chatting casually, and one table with someone seriously working on a laptop. It was quite leisurely.

Rainbow also politely put away her book and instead asked Liang Shi: "Sister Liang, what did you want to talk to Teacher Qi about?"

"Just to say hello," Liang Shi replied. "We knew each other before."

Rainbow frowned, looking quite troubled.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi asked. "What do you want to say?"

Rainbow thought for a moment, then gestured for Liang Shi to lean her ear closer.

"This Monday and Tuesday, Teacher Qi took sick leave and didn't come to work," Rainbow lowered her voice. "On Wednesday we had PE class, and I saw Teacher Qi's knees... they were purple."

"Also, she had really serious marks on her back. I accidentally patted her back before, and then..."

At this point, Rainbow felt very guilty and said dejectedly, "Is Teacher Qi being bullied by bad people?"

Liang Shi frowned, not knowing how to discuss this with a child, so she could only deflect: "That's not clear yet. I'll ask Teacher Qi about it later."

Rainbow nodded.

Liang Shi asked again: "Has Teacher Qi had these kinds of injuries on her body before?"

Rainbow thought carefully. "In April this year, she took half a month off. When she came back, she was limping. I heard the teachers say she seemed to have sprained her ankle while hiking. But that time I also saw her applying medicine to her knees, similar to the wounds she has now."

Because Rainbow was smart, and Zhou Li often couldn't pick her up on time, she spent more time with the teachers than ordinary children and understood more about the situation.

Liang Shi asked Rainbow a few more questions, but since she was still a child after all, she didn't know much more.

But just from this information, it sounded frightening enough.

This meant Qi Jiao had been enduring Mrs. Qi's domestic violence all along.

It had truly reached a level that warranted criminal charges.

After listening, Liang Shi felt heavy-hearted. She took out her phone wanting to text Qi Jiao, but didn't know what to say.

Mrs. Qi's threatening words from last time still echoed in her ears.

Sending this text might not matter to her, but Qi Jiao would still face Mrs. Qi's threats.

So Liang Shi gave up.

She texted Xu Qingzhu asking what she wanted for dinner, and also mentioned that she would be bringing a child home that evening.

¹ A fictional children's story/cartoon mentioned in the novel

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Xu Qingzhu quickly replied: [Whatever the child eats, I'll eat.]

Liang Shi looked at this reply and smiled, casually tapping on the screen: [Okay, you're the same as the child.]

Xu Qingzhu: [?]

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu sent: [Teacher Liang, I feel like you're implying something about me.]

Liang Shi immediately replied: [How could that be?]

—[Be more confident, remove "I feel like."]

Xu Qingzhu: [Furious.jpg]

Liang Shi: [Just kidding, Teacher Xu, continue working.]

Xu Qingzhu: [About to get off work. Teacher Liang is quite comfortable skipping work.]

Liang Shi: [Not bad. After all, compared to Teacher Xu, I'm just a salted fish...]¹

Xu Qingzhu: [Helping your boss take care of a child is also a kind of work. Teacher Liang is essentially someone who loves work.]

Liang Shi: [...]

When it came to being passive-aggressive, she had lost.

Liang Shi smiled and turned off her screen, only to see Ling Dang pouting with an unhappy expression.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi placed the fries in front of her. Ling Dang crossed her arms and didn't eat, so Liang Shi dipped them in some ketchup and brought them to her mouth.

Ling Dang said huffily, "Hmph, I don't want to know about your little secrets!"

Liang Shi: "..."

She smiled helplessly, her smile full of indulgence, but teased Ling Dang anyway: "Then you don't need to know our little secrets."

Ling Dang's eyes widened, looking like two glowing black grapes, but she still ate the fries brought to her mouth.

Liang Shi wiped her hands, then pinched her cheek.

But Ling Dang suddenly looked out the window and excitedly patted Rainbow's shoulder. "Isn't that someone from your class?"

Rainbow followed her gaze and nodded. "Yes, it's Su Yu."

"Isn't it Sheng Yu?" Ling Dang frowned. "I heard Shen Yiran say that was her name."

"I don't know," Rainbow said. "When she introduced herself, she said she was Su Yu."

Hearing the name Su Yu, Liang Shi subconsciously touched the silver bracelet on her wrist and immediately turned to look. She saw one adult and one child who had already pushed open the McDonald's door and walked in.

The woman wore a dark blue trench coat, and light-colored jeans visually added several centimeters to her legs. She wore eight-centimeter stiletto heels, had long brown curly hair, wore sunglasses, and held a delicately beautiful child by the hand as she walked straight to the counter to order. Her voice was crisp and clean. "One A-set meal."

"Hello, is this for here or to go?" the server asked.

"To go," the woman said.

Liang Shi stared intently at her profile. The woman crouched down to look at the child beside her, smoothing down the hair that had been messed up by the wind, and said softly, "You can only drink half a cup of cola, understand?"

The delicately beautiful child nodded, then pointed in their direction and asked, "Mama, can I go say hello to my classmate?"

The woman suddenly looked in Liang Shi's direction, and their eyes met.

Liang Shi immediately looked down at her phone. On the screen was a photo she had just searched for—it was of Su Yao winning the Emerging Designer award on the red carpet over twenty years ago.

Although the person before her had the marks of time on her face, her features were just as they had always been.

Ling Dang suddenly said, "Auntie, she looks so much like Aunt!"²

Liang Shi's breath caught.

But Qi Jiao had told Liang Shi that Su Yu was from a single-parent family, and her mother's name was—Su Mu.

¹ "Salted fish" (鹹魚/咸鱼) is Chinese internet slang for someone who is lazy, unmotivated, or has given up on ambition—like a dried salted fish that just lies there doing nothing

² In Chinese, the term used here is "姑母" (gumu), which specifically refers to one's father's sister (paternal aunt). Ling Dang is referring to Xu Qingzhu, who is Liang Shi's wife and therefore would be considered Ling Dang's aunt by marriage